Chapter Nine

Final Phase

"The concepts of 'ours' and 'not ours' are peace concepts, only, and in war they lose their whole meaning."

—David Ben-Gurion

Operation Yoav was an immediate and stunning success for the IDF. Egyptian forces were driven out of the northern Negev, important towns were captured, and only one major position was able to hold out: an isolated Egyptian force located in al-Faluja, around 20 miles (30 kilometers) northeast of Gaza City. What would become known as the Faluja Pocket would hold out against all IDF attacks for the remainder of the war.

Only one Arab army was in a position to relive the siege of Egyptian forces in Faluja: the Arab Legion. However, as Israel's leaders had correctly predicted, King Abdullah did not order this force to assist his Egyptian ally. Instead, the Arab Legion was directed to occupy the towns of Bethlehem and Hebron, both of which had been abandoned by the retreating Egyptians. Following Operation Yoav, the Egyptian Army was no longer a threat to Israel; while it was able to occupy some territory in the Negev, it was not considered to be capable of mounting a new attack. The IDF quickly turned its attention to the Syrian Army.

Operation Hiram began on October 29 and saw Syrian forces being quickly driven out of Central Galilee. A small number of troops from Lebanon had occupied a handful of villages in the area, and these too were driven out. IDF troops even followed them across the border into Lebanon and occupied several Lebanese villages. In both the north and the south, the IDF had been successful in driving back two of the three Arab armies. The Arab Legion took no part in these actions, essentially remaining neutral as its allies were attacked and driven back.